

A Field Guide to the Medicinal Herb Garden

Growing and using gentle culinary and tea herbs

Planning the Herb Garden

A home medicinal and tea garden can be small and still productive. Most gentle herbs want full sun, well-drained soil, and regular harvesting, which keeps them bushy and productive. Grow what you will actually use, and learn each plant well before relying on it.

Reliable Herbs for the Piedmont

Herb	Grows	Common gentle use
Lemon balm	Perennial, spreads	Calming tea, digestion
Chamomile	Annual/short-lived	Relaxing tea before sleep
Mint	Vigorous perennial	Digestive tea (contain it!)
Echinacea	Perennial	Traditional immune support
Elderberry	Shrub	Syrup from cooked ripe berries
Mullein	Biennial	Soothing respiratory tea

Harvesting & Drying

- Harvest leaves in the morning after dew dries, before flowering for best flavor.
- Bundle and hang in a warm, dark, airy place, or use a low dehydrator.
- Store dried herbs in labeled glass jars away from light and heat.
- Label every jar with the herb and the year — potency fades over time.

Safety First

Note: This guide describes a traditional cultural and culinary practice for educational purposes. It is not medical advice. Herbal preparations are not a substitute for professional care; some herbs interact with medications or are unsafe in pregnancy. Always confirm plant identification and consult a qualified practitioner before use.

- Elderberries must be cooked; raw berries, leaves, and stems are not safe.
- Confirm identification absolutely before using any wild-gathered plant.
- Introduce one herb at a time and watch for any reaction.